

Writing Project 1B: Research Proposal

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To start with my research question, I propose this: “How do online developer communities perceive free labor in the digital world?”

The information gathered from this research question is important because it can give us a window into how many things within the internet function on a day-to-day basis as well as the state of the technology industry at large. Not only that, it can also be interesting to see how people can come together to make wonderful things.

Along with the great things that this free labor brings about on the internet, there are many problems with it too; exploitation, to put it simply. All facets of this topic should be explored to create a better understanding of the world and the internet, and where better to explore them than through the lens of the people behind it all!

This research question absolutely could be of interest to researchers of digital rhetoric, internet studies, cultural studies, and sociology. For digital rhetoric, it is because the topic of free labor in digital spaces, among other things, connects to a core tenet of that field of study, digital labor. For internet studies, it would be because free labor in digital spaces impacts the internet heavily with things like open-source projects that completely change the digital landscape and the Internet’s infrastructure. For cultural studies, free digital labor has created many different nuanced cultures within the Internet to study, like open-source developers, freelancers, game developers (often revenue-share projects), and others. Finally, for sociology, open-source has a lot to go through for social structures to analyze with GitHub repositories and their stars or simply usefulness of a project; additionally, you could also look at hacking initiatives like the ones involved with Google Maps that reward developers with things other than money, like reputation or “social capital”.

If I were to pick an online community to mainly analyze, I’d have to say I’d go with r/developers on Reddit. I would like to use more communities, though. If I could, I would also add in r/INAT, r/opensource, and r/programming. All of these communities have amazing artifacts I’ve found that I could use to synthesize a very competent answer to the research question. These are developer spaces that either are geared towards free labor or have free labor as a recurring topic. The artifacts that talk about this would be good to pull from to show exactly how people in these communities perceive free labor in the digital world and all of the different kinds of free labor (open-source projects, revenue-share gone wrong, big company hacking initiative, etc.)

For what I’m looking for in comments, it will mostly just be discussion about the post. I’ll see if people agree with the sentiments shared by the post, if they disagreed, or if they bring up a point about free labor that other people discuss in comments that reply to it. I’ll take all of that, and analyze the general consensus along with points and counter-points that could be used to create a more compelling answer.

In my secondary sources, I’ll find a lot of evidence, data, and quotes to pull that can compare nicely with whatever artifact I may find in my online communities. The sources allow me to learn about things like the Google Maps VGI initiative along with other instances of digital free labor and exploitation. Referencing those things, it also allows me to help both myself and the audience understand the online discourse from my primary sources. Knowing the facts and data I can get from my secondary sources helps everyone interpret content from posts and the comments.

I plan on using the UCF library search to gather secondary sources while I browse Reddit in my selected online communities along with PullPush Reddit (the tool you showed in class, maybe I got the name wrong) to find and analyze posts and comments. I'll start with broad terms like "free", and go into "free labor" or "free digital labor" for keywords to attempt to find artifacts that match my research question adequately. This is what I've done to find the primary and secondary sources I've already collected, and it has worked out great so far. I'm honestly not really sure what other methods are available to me, unless I misunderstood the question. This way of doing it seems like the obvious choice for any kind of research, and it both works well and gets me the artifacts I need.